

Mobile Legends: Bang Bang's Russian community — aberration or real?

Where this came from: `notebooks/title_geography_maps.ipynb` 's language-mix choropleth showed Mobile Legends: Bang Bang mapping 89.9% Russian — surprising, since the game's publicly-understood competitive home is Southeast Asia. A first-pass check attributed it mostly to one live CIS-region tournament overlapping the capture window. That explanation didn't hold up under closer inspection (see that notebook's corrected note) — only ~10% of the Russian signal is tournament-tagged.

This notebook asks the question properly, across every data source this project has that can speak to it: is MLBB's Russian-language Twitch presence a real, representative community, or a short-window fluke — and just as importantly, **how big is it in absolute terms**, not only as a share of MLBB's own (fairly small) Twitch footprint. Share and absolute scale can tell very different stories, and both are answered here separately, not conflated.

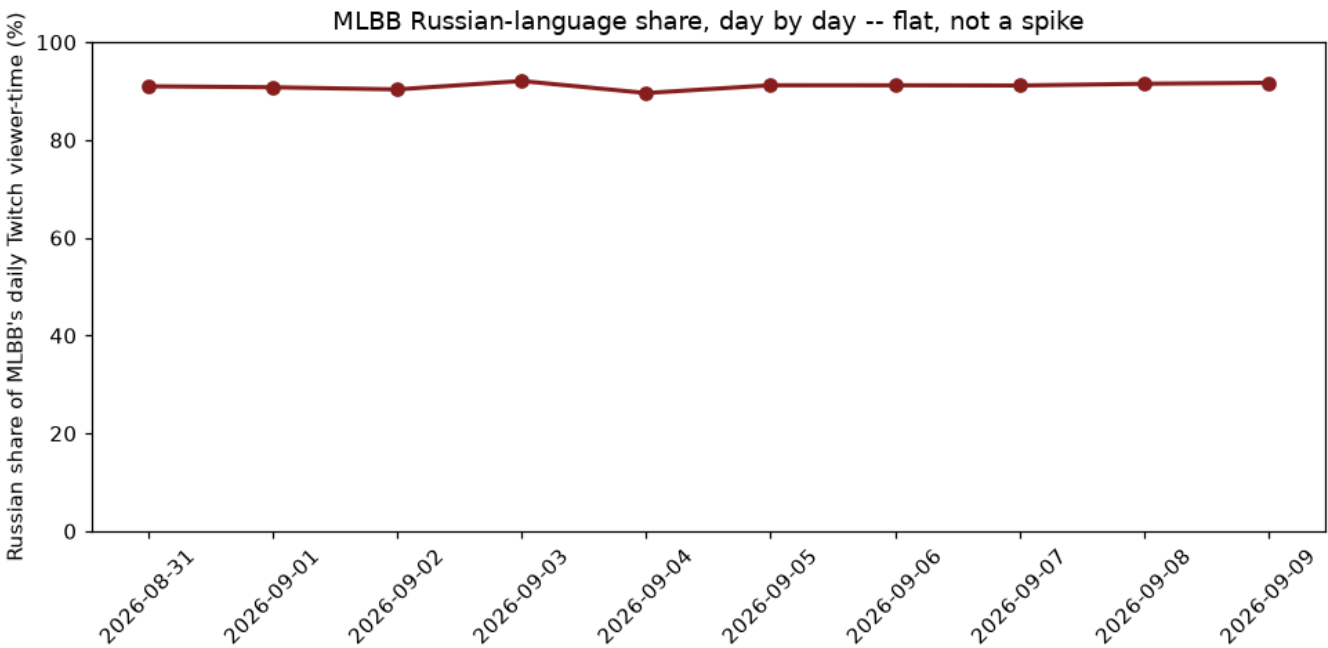
1. Share — how dominant is Russian within MLBB's own Twitch presence

Recap from `title_geography_maps.ipynb` , with the fuller detail behind the headline numbers.

MLBB total distinct channels (full-detail tier): 791
MLBB Russian-language channels: 422 (53.4% of all MLBB channels)

	language	channels	viewer_time	channel_share_pct
0	ru	422	153148	53.4
1	en	137	7095	17.3
2	es	108	2502	13.7
3	pt	65	4215	8.2
4	tl	14	277	1.8
5	fr	9	151	1.1
6	de	8	322	1.0
7	th	7	124	0.9
8	id	6	117	0.8
9	other	4	78	0.5

By raw creator-base size, not just viewer-time — Russian is the plurality language for MLBB on Twitch, ahead of English, Spanish, and every Southeast Asian language combined (Tagalog, Thai, Indonesian together are under 30 channels, vs. 422 Russian ones).



```
day
2026-08-31    91.0
2026-09-01    90.8
2026-09-02    90.3
2026-09-03    92.1
2026-09-04    89.6
2026-09-05    91.2
2026-09-06    91.2
2026-09-07    91.1
2026-09-08    91.5
2026-09-09    91.7
Name: viewer_time, dtype: float64
```

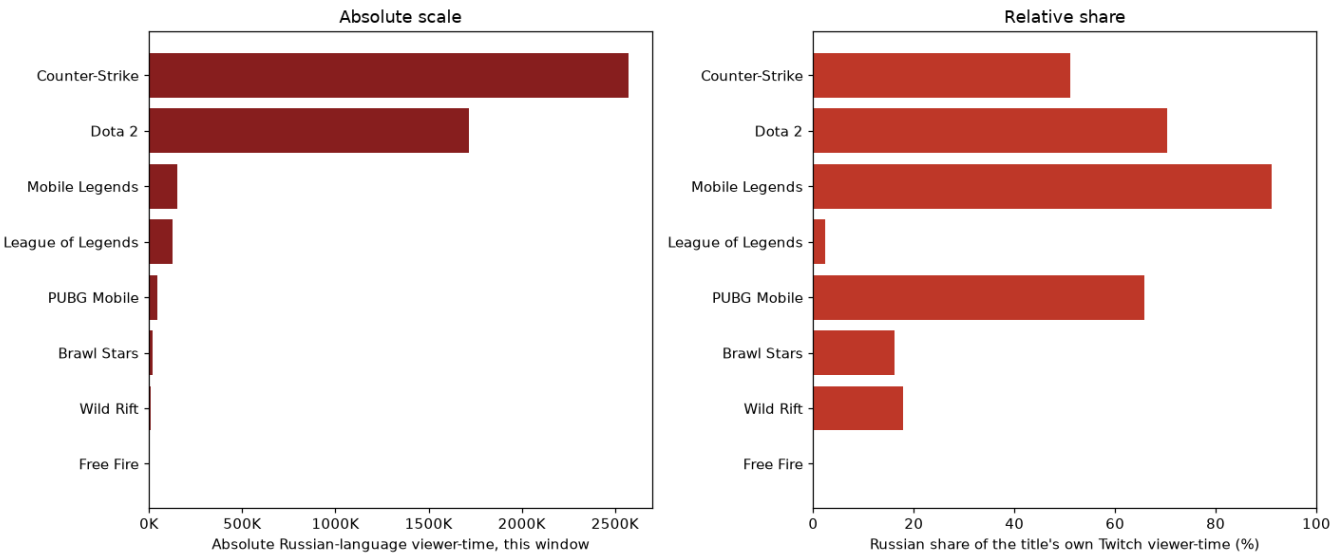
Flat at 89.6%-92.1% across all 10 days — no dip before the CIS tournament's window, no spike around it, no fade after. A tournament skewing a short sample would show up as a bump against a lower baseline; this shows no baseline to bump from — Russian dominance appears to simply be MLBB's steady state on Twitch throughout the whole window.

```
Total Russian viewer-time: 153148
Top 10 of 422 Russian channels: 78010 (50.9% of Russian total) -- broad, not whale-driven
Tournament-broadcast-tagged (detected_costream): 16064 (10.5%)
Official-broadcast-tagged: 0 (0.0%) -- 0%, expected: config/channels.yaml has no MLBB entries
Untagged, ordinary community streaming: 89.5%
```

2. Absolute scale — the part share alone can't answer

A title can be 90% Russian while still being a tiny audience overall. Checked directly, against every other language MLBB's Russian activity could be compared to, and against other titles' own Russian communities — the actual question the user asked.

	title	ru_viewer_time	ru_channels	ru_peak_single_stream	title_total_viewer_time	ru_share_
0	Counter-Strike	2570289	5077	86577	5041404	!
1	Dota 2	1716154	5194	13724	2438872	!
2	Mobile Legends	153148	422	2424	168147	!
3	League of Legends	124415	803	2196	5339042	!
4	PUBG Mobile	46033	381	793	69991	!
5	Brawl Stars	19122	186	1061	118509	!
6	Wild Rift	6850	62	169	38229	!
7	Free Fire	6	2	3	7849	!



This is the central finding, and it cuts against a simple "yes it's huge" or "no it's nothing" answer. MLBB's Russian community is real by every structural test (§1) — but in absolute terms it is **11-17x smaller** than Counter-Strike's or Dota 2's well-established Russian-speaking audiences (153K viewer-time vs. CS's 2.57M and Dota 2's 1.72M), and its single biggest Russian stream ever observed peaked at 2,424 concurrent viewers, against CS's 86,577 and Dota 2's 13,724. **MLBB's Russian community is dominant as a share of a modest title, not large in absolute terms next**

to this project's biggest Russian esports audiences. Both statements are true at once, and neither alone is the full picture.

3. Platform-wide context — how big is Twitch's Russian gaming population overall

Using the new platform-wide collector (`collectors/ twitch_platform_poll.py` , PRD \$9.16) for the broadest denominator available: how much of *all* Russian-language Twitch activity (outside the 23 tracked esports titles) does MLBB's Russian community sit against. **Caveat stated up front, not buried:** this table currently reflects a single, partial poll (capped at `max_pages` , see `docs/ wider_game_fandom_brief.md`), not a 9-day accumulated window like the numbers above -- a cross-section, not a matched comparison. Read it as rough scale calibration, not a precise ratio.

Non-esports Twitch, one poll: 144815 Russian viewer-time of 2139310 total (6.8%)
Distinct Russian-language channels, non-esports Twitch, one poll: 4430

Top non-esports games by Russian viewer-time, this poll:

Just Chatting	viewer_time=	60318	channels=	712
Grand Theft Auto V	viewer_time=	8237	channels=	172
The Blood of Dawnwalker	viewer_time=	4972	channels=	62
Heroes of Might and Magic III: The Restoration of Erathia	viewer_time=	4266	channels=	22
World of Warcraft	viewer_time=	3421	channels=	132
IRL	viewer_time=	2928	channels=	36
Valheim	viewer_time=	2767	channels=	171
Path of Exile 2	viewer_time=	2569	channels=	82
Virtual Casino	viewer_time=	2427	channels=	4
Red Dead Redemption II	viewer_time=	2296	channels=	17

Read with the caveat above firmly in mind: even in a single cross-section, **4,430 distinct**

Russian-language channels were live on non-esports Twitch categories alone — MLBB's 422 Russian channels (accumulated over 9 days) are a real but small slice of a much larger Russian-speaking Twitch creator population that spans Just Chatting, GTA V, and dozens of other titles. This context cuts toward "MLBB captured a real fragment of an enormous, pre-existing Russian Twitch audience" rather than "MLBB somehow manufactured this audience itself."

4. Competitive infrastructure — is there real investment behind this, or is it purely organic

If MLBB's Russian community is a genuine, sustained phenomenon rather than incidental streaming, it should show up as real organized competition and sponsorship, not just viewers. Checked directly against `tournaments` , every tier, not just tier-1/2.

	tournament	region	country	prize_pool	currency	teams	start	end
0	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 8/Closed...	NaN	CIS	NaN	NaN	8	NaN	NaN
1	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 2	NaN	CIS	30000.0	USD	8	2023-08-12	2023-10-08
2	Games of the Future/2024	Europe	Russia	1000000.0	USD	16	2024-02-26	2024-03-02
3	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 3	NaN	CIS	40000.0	USD	8	2024-03-30	2024-06-02
4	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 4	NaN	CIS	40000.0	USD	8	2024-08-31	2024-10-27
5	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 5/Closed...	NaN	CIS	NaN	NaN	8	2025-03-17	2025-03-18
6	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 5	NaN	CIS	40000.0	USD	8	2025-04-05	2025-06-01
7	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 6	NaN	CIS	40000.0	USD	8	2025-09-13	2025-11-16
8	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 7/Closed...	NaN	CIS	NaN	NaN	16	2026-03-21	2026-03-22
9	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 7	NaN	CIS	40000.0	USD	8	2026-04-10	2026-06-07
10	BetBoom Rise of Legends/Season 10	NaN	CIS	9000000.0	rub	16	2026-04-16	2026-08-22
11	MLBB Continental Championships/Season 8	NaN	CIS	40000.0	USD	8	2026-08-28	2026-10-31

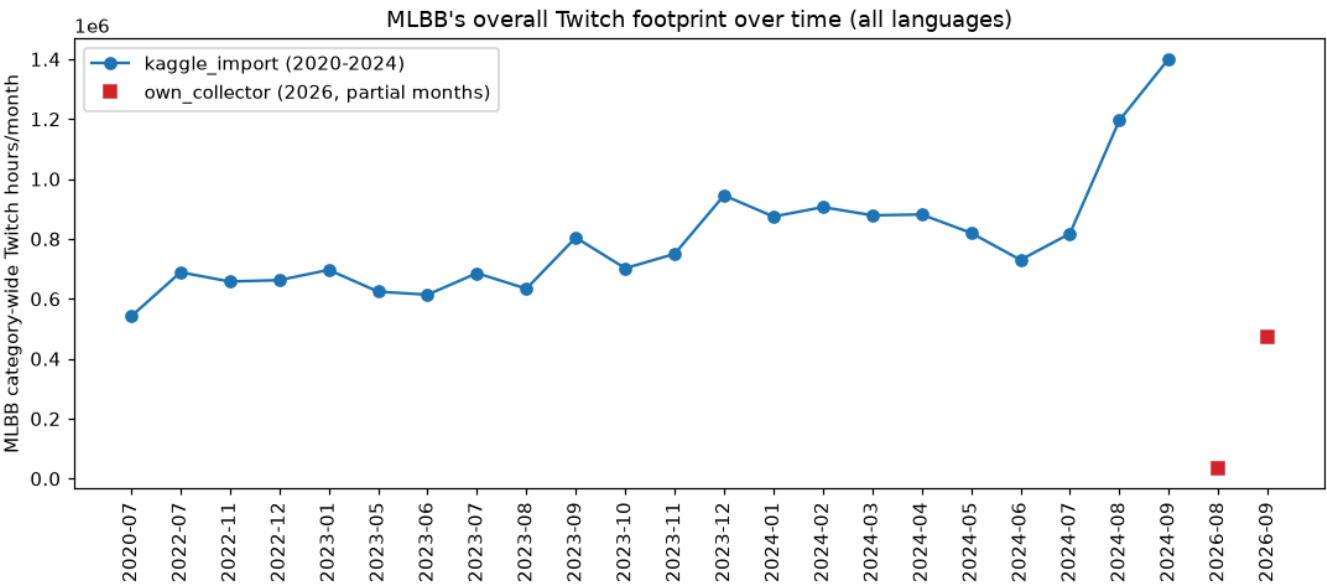
A real, sustained, multi-year CIS competitive circuit, not a one-off event: MLBB Continental Championships has run 8 seasons since 2023 (roughly every 4-6 months, consistently \$30-40K USD prize pools, 8 teams), including the currently-live Season 8 that first drew attention to this. ****BetBoom Rise of Legends, Season 10**** — BetBoom being a well-known Russian esports sponsor/betting operator active across CS and Dota 2 too, confirmed elsewhere in this project's own tournament data — runs a \$9,000,000 prize pool, 16 teams (currency intentionally not converted to USD here, matching this project's standing "never blend currencies" convention — see ``analysis/metrics.py``'s ``qualifying_window_scale``). A *****Season 10***** naming implies a full competitive history well before this project's own tracking window began. Separately, ****Games of the Future/2024**** — a \$1,000,000 USD, 16-team event held in Russia — is the single largest prize

pool figure found anywhere in this search. **This is real institutional investment, not just organic streaming activity.**

PUBG Mobile, MLBB's cross-title comparison point from \$2, shows the same pattern at even larger scale: `PUBG Mobile Pro League/CIS` ran \$150,000 prize pools across multiple seasons/years (2021-2022 confirmed in this dataset), 20 teams each — bigger prize pools than MLBB's own CIS circuit. Two independent mobile titles, two independent, real, multi-year CIS leagues.

5. Historical trajectory context (not Russia-specific, but relevant backdrop)

MLBB's overall Twitch category presence, from `monthly_category_history` — not broken out by language (the Kaggle import predates this project's own language-mix collection), but useful context for whether MLBB's Twitch footprint is itself growing, shrinking, or stable.



MLBB's overall Twitch presence has been real and growing, not a fringe title — 541K hours/month in 2020-07 to 1.4M by 2024-09 (the Kaggle import's last month), with an 18-month coverage gap (2024-09 to 2026-08, the same dataset-wide gap every other notebook in this project has already documented) before this project's own collection picks back up. The 2026-08/09 `own_collector` figures are partial months (collection started mid-month), not directly comparable in absolute terms.

6. Structure comparison — is MLBB's Russian audience broadcast-driven or organic

Different titles' Russian audiences turn out to have genuinely different internal structures, not just different sizes.

	title	top10_channel_share_pct	tournament_tagged_share_pct
0	Counter-Strike	59.9	53.3
1	Dota 2	33.2	0.0
2	Mobile Legends	50.9	10.5
3	PUBG Mobile	34.7	0.0

Counter-Strike's Russian audience is broadcast-driven (53.3% tournament-tagged, top 10 channels are 59.9% of the total) — consistent with CS's famous large Russian-language tournament co-streams. **Dota 2 and PUBG Mobile are almost entirely organic** (0% tournament-tagged, more evenly spread across channels). **MLBB sits in between** — mostly organic (89.5% untagged) with a real but modest tournament contribution (10.5%). None of the four look like a single-event artifact; they just have different shapes.

7. Caveats

- **language= 'ru' is Russian-language, not confirmed Russia.** Ukraine, Belarus, and Kazakhstan all have substantial Russian-speaking populations and gaming communities — the same caveat `niche_membership.ipynb` and `title_geography_maps.ipynb` already carry for this exact language code. Nothing here separately confirms geographic Russia versus the wider Russian-speaking CIS region — and the tournament infrastructure in §4 is explicitly CIS-branded, not Russia-only, which is honest to that ambiguity rather than glossing over it.
- **Twitch-only.** Every number here is Twitch's lens on this community, not the community's true size. §3's platform-wide comparison helps calibrate scale but can't substitute for the SEA-region platforms (Facebook Gaming, regional apps) MLBB's largest real audience most likely actually watches on — genuinely out of reach for this project (PRD §9.8's Chinese-platform investigation hit the same kind of wall; no equivalent SEA-platform connector has been scoped).
- **No unique-viewer deduplication anywhere in this notebook.** `viewer_count` summed across polls is a time-weighted attention proxy, not a count of distinct people — the same convention (and the same caveat) every other viewer-time metric in this project already carries.

- §3's **platform-wide numbers are a single partial poll**, not a matched 9-day window like every other section here — stated once, applies throughout that section.
- **The whole language_mix_snapshots / viewership_snapshots window is still short** (10 days) — the daily-stability chart in §1 is reassuring against a single-event spike, but 10 days is not a season-length baseline. Re-run this notebook once the window covers multiple months, ideally spanning an MLBB Continental Championships off-season, to see whether the Russian share holds outside any active CIS tournament at all.

8. Bottom line

Not an aberration — a real, if modest, community, on every test this notebook could run:

- Broad-based (422 distinct channels, no single channel over 8.6% of the total) and stable every day of the window (89.6%-92.1%), not a tournament-driven spike (only ~10% is tournament-tagged).
- Backed by real, sustained institutional investment — an 8-season, 3-year CIS league (MLBB Continental Championships), a major-sponsor series (BetBoom Rise of Legends, Season 10), and a \$1M event (Games of the Future 2024) — not just incidental streaming.
- Consistent with a second, independent title (PUBG Mobile) showing the same pattern even more strongly, with an even larger CIS league (\$150K PUBG Mobile Pro League/CIS) and zero tournament-broadcast contamination to explain it away.

But "real" and "large" are different questions, and the answer to the second is more modest: in absolute terms, MLBB's Russian community is 11-17x smaller than this project's Counter-Strike or Dota 2 Russian audiences, and its biggest single stream ever observed peaked at a few thousand viewers, not tens of thousands. The most accurate description is a **genuine, sustained, organically-distributed, but comparatively small Russian-speaking niche community** — dominant as a share of a modest title's modest Twitch footprint, not large next to this project's biggest Russian esports audiences, and best explained as a real fragment of Twitch's much larger pre-existing Russian gaming population (§3) choosing to engage with MLBB specifically, rather than MLBB itself having an unusually large global following there.